

ing that balanced leadership styles translate into better client engagement, stronger governance, and sustainable business performance. “As a result, the value of women’s leadership across the BFSI sector is being acknowledged more strongly than ever,” says Vora.

Gupta says women bring a distinct leadership energy—one that blends empathy, resilience, and long-term thinking. “CEOs today manage multiple stakeholders—investors, employees, customers, and regulators—and that ability to balance perspectives and build trust comes naturally to women,” she says.

Padalkar doesn’t believe women bring “less or more” energy—they simply bring their own strengths, she says.



## AS MORE WOMEN ENTER THE BFSI SECTOR, FIRMS HAVE REALISED DIVERSE LEADERSHIP STRENGTHENS TEAMS

They bring in some fresh perspectives that might even be contrarian to popular thinking. “Given our consumer set is 50% female, companies would naturally benefit from taking advantage of all points of view, be it in driving strategy or customer outreach,” says Padalkar.

Besides, women tend to be careful with money, strong with relationships, and comfortable working as a team, explains Karnad. Financial institutions run on trust and empathy, and women handle these aspects naturally, she adds.

Karnad’s point is also supported by an IMF study, titled “*Banking on Women Leaders: A Case for More?*”. Banks with more women on boards and in leadership roles show greater stability, the study states. This includes lower non-performing loans.

“In a world increasingly shaped by technology and AI, human qualities like empathy, judgement, and emotional intelligence are becoming even more valuable. And beyond gender, any form of diverse thinking makes

organisations stronger. Finance is no longer just about numbers; it’s about behaviour, trust, and sustainability. It’s heartening that this difference is now being valued, not just acknowledged,” says Gupta.

### ACCELERATING WOMEN’S RISE

Karnad says policies favourable to women alone are not enough. “Families and organisations both play a role. When companies invest in safety, flexible work, childcare support, and clear action against harassment, women do not have to choose between career and home. When families back their daughters and daughters-in-law the way they support sons, more women reach leadership,” she says.

Vora suggests that normalising flexible work arrangements, providing accessible childcare options, and fostering environments where both men and women share domestic responsibilities, can remove significant barriers that hold women back from reaching their full leadership potential. “This kind of systemic change would not only support women but also strengthen organisations by retaining diverse talent and enabling leaders to bring their best selves to work consistently,” she says.

The most important thing is to ensure that the hiring funnel of new recruits includes a good share of women, suggests Padalkar. The second is to provide a structured career path for women along with mentoring, and the third is the availability of flexible working arrangements during certain times in their careers. These factors can play a big role in enabling companies to produce women leaders, says Padalkar.

Gupta of Edelweiss says the real game-changer now could be support—especially around the years when women juggle careers and young families. “Having been a young mother myself, I’ve seen how critical mentoring, trust, and mental health support are during that phase. A woman doesn’t just need six months of maternity leave—she needs years of understanding, flexibility, and handholding. A six-month-old baby doesn’t stop needing a mother,” she adds.

Culture also matters enormously—like the language used in offices, the way managers behave, and the everyday signals that either include or exclude. “And finally, role modelling. We need more examples that show finance isn’t just for men, that ambition and family can coexist, and that women can lead in their own authentic way,” adds Gupta.

Clearly, women in BFSI are leading from the front, and it’s only a matter of time before other sectors witness a similar trend as technology, digital adoption and flexible work continue to break long-standing barriers. **BT**